Zhuo Chen

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Education

Fudan University (FDU) Shanghai, China

M.A. in Political Science Sep. 2023 – Jun. 2026

- GPA: 3.84/4.00, Rank: 1/12
- Core Modules: Comparative Politics, Political Methodology, Chinese Politics, African Politics

Hunan Normal University (HNNU) Changsha, China

B.A. in Political Science and Public Administration (Distinction) Sep. 2019 – Jun. 2023

Interdisciplinary Program for Outstanding Undergraduates (Shicheng Class) Sep. 2020 – Jun. 2023

- GPA: 4.58/5.00, Rank: 1/31
- Core Modules: Political Theory, Chinese Politics, Methodology in Social Science, Political Economy

Work in Progress

Tracks of Division: The Effects of Standard Gauge Railways on National Identity in Kenya

- Employed a difference-in-differences approach (DiD) and GIS methods to identify the effects of Kenyan Standard Gauge Railway (SGR) on national identity
- Third Prize in the Excellent Paper Award of the Harare Forum for Africa

African Socialism and State-building in Kenya: The Origin of Harambee Movement during the Cold War

- Leveraged a process-tracing method and historical archives to examine the genesis of Harambee movement in Kenya, emphasizing the social realities surrounding national independence distinct from "proxy war"
- First Prize in the Excellent Paper Award of the Fudan University Postgraduate Forum (*Guowu Luntan*)

Democracy or Ethnicity? The Impacts of the Devolution Reform on Public Goods Provision in Kenya

- Utilized critical case analysis in Kenya to assess the influence of the Majimbo movement, specifically the devolution reform in 2010, on the provision and quality of public services
- Awarded Excellent Grade for Term Paper in the "African Politics and Society" Course

Master's Thesis

The Effects of Railway Upgrading on National Identity in Africa: Evidence from Kenya and Nigeria

- Employed public opinion data from Afrobarometer and developed an original railway dataset, including colonial-era meter gauge railways (MGR) and new-built standard gauge railways (SGR) for Kenya and Nigeria
- Utilized a difference-in-differences (DiD) approach to examine the causal relationship between railway upgrading and national identity, finding the effects are context-specific
- Thesis defense awarded an Excellent grade

Undergraduate Thesis

Embeddedness and Coaptation: Strategic Development of Supply and Marketing Cooperatives in Rural China

- Utilized a critical case of supply and marketing cooperative (SMC) in Hunan Province to examine state-market relationships, and analyzed the case through the lens of Granovetter's embeddedness
- Argued that SMCs' development is not only related to the embeddedness but also their own coaptation, thus forming bidirectional interaction between state and market, particularly after 1978
- Awarded the *Excellent Undergraduate Thesis of Hunan Normal University*

Review Essays and Others

- Review of Deborah Brautigam, *The Dragon's Gift: The Real Story of China in Africa*, XinTianXueShe, 2025
- Review of Poppy Cullen, *Kenya and Britain after Independence: Beyond Neo-Colonialism*, 2024

Research and Teaching Experience

Research

- Research Assistant for Prof. Yuhua Wang, Harvard 2024
- Research Assistant for Prof. Cai (Vera) Zuo, FDU 2023-2026
- Research Assistant for Dr. Wei Ye, CUHK-Shenzhen 2026

Teaching

- Teaching Assistant for Prof. Jodie Yuzhou Sun, *China, the Third World and the Cold War* (Fudan International Summer Session), FDU 2026
- Teaching Assistant for Prof. Jodie Yuzhou Sun, *Modern African and the World*, FDU 2025, 2026
  Awarded Outstanding Teaching Assistance
- Teaching Assistant for Prof. Zhongren Li, *Political Theory*, HNNU 2023

Field Research

- Urbanization, Industrialization and Railway Development, Nigeria Aug. 2026
- Urbanization, Industrialization and Railway Development, Kenya Aug. 2026
- Rural Development and Modernization in Africa, Zimbabwe Aug. 2025
- Rural Revitalization in Yangtze River Delta, Shanghai Nov. 2024
- Local Governance Modernization and Rural Revitalization, Daqing Jul. 2024
- Administrative Burden of Grassroots Cadres, Nanjing May 2024
- China Social Governance Survey (CSGS), Changsha Feb. 2023
- Rural Development and Local Governance, Dalian Dec. 2022
- Community Governance for Poverty Alleviation Relocation, Changsha Aug. 2020
- Residential Life during COVID-19 Pandemic, Wuhan/Telephone Survey Jul. 2020

Methodology Training

- Summer Social Science Research Methods Program (Advanced Methods in Causal Inference), Shanghai Jiao Tong University (SJTU) 2024
- Political Science Research Methods (Research Design), FDU 2023
- Political Science Research Methods (STATA) 2021
- Qualitative Methods in Political Science (NVivo) 2021
- Quantitative Methods in Social Science (SPSS) 2020
- Methods of Field Research (Survey, Interview, Observation) 2020

Fellowships and Awards

Scholarships and Grants (Selected)

- National Scholarship (Top 1%) 2025, 2022
- Gu-Jing Scholarship (Top 1%) 2025
- First-class Scholarship of Fudan University (Top 20%) 2025, 2026
- Yang-Shuda Scholarship (Top 1%) 2022
- First-class Scholarship of Hunan Normal University (Top 10%) 2020-2022
- Fudan Social Engagement Project Grant 2024-2025
- National Innovation and Entrepreneurship Training Project Grant 2022-2023

Awards (Selected)

- Excellent Graduates in Shanghai 2026
- Excellent Students in Fudan University 2024, 2025
- Outstanding Communist Youth League Members of Fudan University 2025
- Excellent Graduates in Hunan Province 2023
- Excellent Graduates in Hunan Normal University 2023
- Excellent Students in Hunan Normal University 2020-2022
- Top Ten Communist Youth League Members of Hunan Normal University 2023
- Top Ten Student Union Leaders of Hunan Normal University 2022
- First Prize of the *Zhexun Cup* National Final 2022
- Second Prize in the Excellent Paper Award of the National Undergraduate Symposium on Political Science 2022

Seminars and Conference Presentations

- The First Beijing-Shanghai Forum of African Studies, Shanghai, China 2026
- Workshop on *China-Africa Relations at 70: Knowledge, Culture, and Global Partnerships*), Ningbo and Shanghai, China 2026
- Fudan University Postgraduate Forum (*Guowu Luntan*), Shanghai, China 2025
- Harare Forum for Africa, Harare, Zimbabwe 2025
- Chinese Community of Political Science and International Relations Annual Conference, Beijing, China 2025
- Seminar on *the Research Platform for Quantitative Social Science and the Theory of the Global South*, Shanghai, China 2025
- National Undergraduate Symposium on Political Science, Guangzhou, China 2022

Selected Talks

- Invited speaker, "The Political Development in Zimbabwe," Shanghai Africa Talk in Sino-Africa Hub 2026
- Invited speaker, "African Development: Data and Field," Political Scientists (*Zhengzhi Xueren*) 2025

Extra-curriculum Activities / Volunteer Work

- Group Leader, China-Africa Shanghai International Network (CASIN) 2025-present
- Volunteer, SIRPA Research Design Workshop, FDU 2025-2026
- Secretary, Communist Youth League Branch of SIRPA, FDU 2023-2026
- Group Leader, Interview Section of the *Political Scientists* (*Zhengzhi Xueren*) 2022-2024
- Deputy Secretary, Communist Youth League Branch in Changsha County 2022-2023
- President, Student Union of SOPA, HNNU 2021-2022

Additional Information

Computer Skills: R, Stata, Python, ArcGIS, QGIS, fsQCA, Gephi, LaTeX
Language: Chinese (native), English (IELTS: 7.5), Swahili (beginner)

Last Updated: Oct. 2026